

{Head} When teachers learn

{Intro} Professional teachers beat neglected facilitators every school day of the week, write Pim Pollen and Ben Laker

{Body}

Student-led projects and DIY learning strategies might have found new popularity in 21st century Education – but without professional, knowledgeable, engaged teachers, such strategies will see students (and schools) fail.

Take heart, then, in our latest research: teachers want more support, more knowledge and improved skills. They want to be ready for the 21st century Education. They want to be the best they can be.

{Box-out} Pop quiz

Q: What is the number one indicator of student performance in reading and math?

A: Teacher quality

{Close box-out}

Most school governors and board members around the world have no link to education beyond their time spent as students. With no experience behind a teacher's desk, they cannot be expected to intuit nor anticipate the challenges and opportunities of contemporary education. But the people who do – educators themselves – [are rarely asked for their input at this level.](#)

Almost 75,000 teachers and support staff from The Netherlands, Italy, Germany, Turkey, South Africa and Mozambique responded to our request for more information about their roles and challenges. Using self-assessments of the group's knowledge-competencies, skills and ambitions, we have been able to put together a complete picture of how teachers see themselves and, importantly, how they would like to grow in the years to come.

{Graphic box-out} The results are in

What we can do

- ✓ Manage behaviour

- ✓ Maintain pedagogical climates
- ✓ Prepare learning activities
- ✓ Foster a healthy learning attitude in the classroom
- ✓ Maintain optimum contact with students
- ✓ Encourage social and emotional development
- ✓ Preserve well-being
- ✓ Incorporate the perspective of parents into own

What we can't do

- ✖ Use evidence-based research effectively
- ✖ Embrace innovative capabilities
- ✖ Embed and implement preventive programs
- ✖ Knowledge of current educational and behavioural science
- ✖ Knowledge of current developmental psychology and inclusive education
- ✖ Knowledge of developments in society
- ✖ Different methods for cooperation

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In general, teachers believe they are people- people, with a good grasp of interpersonal and organizational competencies. They also pride themselves on being resourceful and capable of working together with the environment and parents.

Where teachers see themselves failing, however, is in whether or not they have enough knowledge of a subject, evidence- based educational and behaviour sciences, and developments in society.

Without speculating on the cause of this (for teachers) confidence-busting and (for parents and students) inconvenient truth, the reality that our teachers do not believe they have enough knowledge is worrying, to say the least.

And, facing bursting classrooms, the future's many distractions and ever-deepening budget cuts, now is the time for leadership to act.

{Graphic box-out} What teachers want to learn

Teachers want to attain the highest levels of specific skills such as:

- ▷ Communicating with parents
- ▷ Finding help for student development problems
- ▷ Devising and enforcing more rules for dealing with behaviour

- ▷ Giving students more space
- ▷ Preparing for learning activities

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With analyses of the opinions and insights of teachers actively serving students every day, leadership has the opportunity to determine starting points and quantifiable aims for professional development.

Allowing teachers to self-report professional development ambitions also provides valuable insight into how effective – or not – a strategy really is. For example, we asked the sample to rate their progress towards annual goals. Such insights could prove especially valuable as showing results of teacher professional development in student test scores could take time.

{Graphic box-out} The long and winding road

Teachers see themselves as far from these ambitions today as ever

- Evaluating and reflecting on learning goals after lessons
- Being aware of and understanding one's thought processes (metacognition)
- Conducting and understanding evidence-based research
- Developing self-efficacy/responsibility
- Inclusive education
- Having knowledge of current educational and behavioural science
- Being up to date with developmental science and inclusive education
- Having a strong grasp of learning objectives and strategies
- Producing useful extra lesson materials

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{Xhead} Join the learning community

Sharing teacher insights can also foster arguably the most effective learning strategy around: the professional learning community (PLC). The professional development equivalent of high performing teams in organizations, PLCs are groups of teachers who commit to the achievement of better learning outcomes for pupils. In perfect PLCs, members undertake dedicated research and share learnings with each other, shifting their focus from didactic, one-way transfers of information to continuous learning as a team. Profoundly affecting the practices of schooling, PLCs are